

The Post-active ORBm and BMAp ensemble: what it is, and whether relapse needs it

Proposal for the next phase — two experiments on the two regions our whole-brain TRAP screen selected

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Morphine lick-PR / TRAP2;Ai14 / Xenium

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WHAT I AM ASKING FOR

1. Approval to run the Xenium pilot with Alina's lab in September, using the base mouse brain panel on tissue we already have.
2. Approval to order the custom probe panel in October once pilot QC passes.
3. Agreement on one design change to the chemogenetics plan: test at protracted abstinence rather than inside the 3-day Post window. Slides 8-9 show why the original plan would have produced a false negative.
4. Sign-off on group sizes. My first sketch (n=4) has ~29% power; I propose it as an expression pilot and a powered cohort behind it.

Where we are

Three pieces of work are finished and feed directly into the next phase

1 WHOLE-BRAIN TRAP SCREEN (done)	2 REGION SELECTION (done)	3 PROBE PANEL (done)
20 mice, 10 Active / 10 Passive, terminal design: each mouse is sacrificed at one behavioural phase. Phases sampled: During, Post, Withdrawal, Reinstatement. Readout: tdTomato+ cell density per Allen region, Active vs Passive within phase.	7 candidate regions carried forward for spatial transcriptomics: ORBm, Aid, CA, BMAp, LM, RE, CP. Selection rule: Active > Passive in the craving phases (Post and Reinstatement) and still separated during Withdrawal. ORBm and BMAp are the two I propose to take forward now.	Built from Allen Whole Mouse Brain 10X: per-subclass discriminating markers plus GPCR specificity tiers. 168 genes covering 20 Allen subclass populations across the two regions; 77 of them are the minimum that still identifies all 20. Code and audit trail on GitHub.

The screen has told us WHERE and WHEN. It cannot tell us WHAT those neurons are, and it cannot tell us whether the behaviour needs them. Those are the two experiments in this deck.

The result that drives the next phase

Active–Passive TRAP density separates at Post and Reinstatement — not while the mice are taking morphine

Region	Cluster	Active – Passive (craving phases)	Take forward?
RE	4	1.19	
ORBm	1	1.04	YES — Experiment 1 + 2
CA	1	0.97	
LM	4	0.96	
Ald	1	0.85	
BMAp	4	0.74	YES — Experiment 1 + 2
CP	4	0.31	

Where the Active–Passive difference appears across the 18-day paradigm



■ morphine ■ water ■ fixed ratio

What the number is

– Active minus Passive tdTomato+ density, z-scored within phase, averaged over Post and Reinstatement.

What the phase pattern means

- The difference is not largest during morphine taking. It is largest at Post and again at Reinstatement, and it narrows during Withdrawal.
- So the ensemble that distinguishes a mouse that earned its morphine from a mouse that merely received it is engaged at Post and re-engaged at relapse.

Why ORBm and BMAp specifically

- They come from the two different clusters, so together they sample a cortical and an amygdalar node rather than two versions of the same signal.
- Both have independent opioid literature: OFC is required for incubated oxycodone and heroin craving; amygdala ensembles are required for incubated craving across several drugs.

Limitation I want to be explicit about

– This is a correlation from a terminal design with 4-6 mice per phase. It is a hypothesis generator, not a causal claim. That is what Experiment 2 is for.

Two questions, two experiments

Experiment 1 gives us the target. Experiment 2 gives us the causal claim.

Q1 WHAT ARE THESE NEURONS? → EXPERIMENT 1: Xenium

Cell-type identity of the Post-tagged ensemble in ORBm and BMAP, in situ, at single-cell resolution.

Which of the 20 Allen subclasses the tdTomato+ cells actually belong to — is the Active-specific signal one population or many?

Which druggable GPCRs those specific cells express.

Whether the Post ensemble and the relapse ensemble are the same cells (tdTomato and Fos co-detected in the same section).

Output: a defensible molecular target, and the probe panel is already built.

Q2 IS THE BEHAVIOUR NECESSARY? → EXPERIMENT 2: TRAP-chemogenetics

Silence the Post-tagged ensemble and ask whether morphine seeking falls.

Hypothesis: inhibiting the Post ensemble reduces seeking and relapse in Active mice, and does not in yoked Passive mice.

The Active-only prediction is the strong part of the hypothesis — it makes the experiment falsifiable rather than merely descriptive.

Output: a causal statement about a specific ensemble in a specific region.

This experiment needs one design change from my first sketch. Slides 8-9.

Together they answer one sentence: the Post-active ensemble in region X consists of cell type Y expressing receptor Z, and relapse requires it. Either half alone is a weaker paper.

Experiment 1 — Xenium on the Post-tagged ensemble

One design choice does most of the work: tag at Post, read out at relapse

	Specification	Why this and not something else
Mice	TRAP2;Ai14 (Fos2A-iCreER × Ai14) JAX 030323 × 007914	Ai14 is the reporter you have chosen; tdTomato mRNA is the TRAP tag Xenium reads.
Groups	Active n=3, Passive n=3	Pilot scale. Statistics caveat on the next slide.
Tag	4-OHT 50 mg/kg i.p. immediately after the behaviour day 12 session (Post day 2)	TRAP2 labels within ~6 h centred on the injection, so this captures the Post state.
Behaviour	Unchanged, days 1-18 (FR, Pre, During, Post, Withdrawal, Re-exposure)	Keeping the paradigm identical means the whole-brain TRAP result still maps onto it.
Abstinence	Days 19-31, home cage	Lets tdTomato accumulate and lets craving incubate.
Readout day	Day 32: cue-induced seeking test, sacrifice 90 min later	20 days after tagging: well past your 10-day minimum, and Fos from the test is at peak.
Tissue	ORBm and BMAp coronal sections; Active and Passive on the SAME slide	Puts the group comparison inside a slide instead of across slides.
Readouts	tdTomato (Post ensemble) + Fos (relapse ensemble) + 20 subclasses + GPCRs	The overlap of tdTomato and Fos is the single most informative measurement here.

Key point: tagging at Post and reading out at relapse turns one experiment into two measurements — what the Post ensemble is, and how much of it comes back at relapse.

Experiment 1 — the panel is built, with one procurement risk

168 genes in four blocks; the risk is the 100-gene cap on custom add-ons

Block	What it answers	BMAp	ORBm	Union
1 Cell-type unique markers	Which of the 20 populations is this cell?	68	77	—
2 Cell-type-specific GPCRs	Druggable AND informative about cell type	6	3	—
3 Broad GPCRs / shared markers	Druggable but group-level only	29	29	—
4 IEG + reporter + backbone	Was it active, was it TRAPped, what class	21	19	—
TOTAL genes to order		124	128	168
Minimum that still IDs all 20		38	52	77

BLOCK 4 IS THE TRAP READOUT — 4 GENES NEED CUSTOM PROBES

tdTomato and iCre are not mouse genes. Xenium supports exogenous targets, but 10x does not validate them, so these are at our risk.

tdTomato = the permanent tag (Ai14). iCre = the driver, which separates cells that expressed the driver from cells that completed recombination.

Fos, Npas4 and Arc give activity at the time of the test; Slc17a7 / Slc17a6 / Gad1 / Gad2 give the neurotransmitter class.

PROCUREMENT RISK — RESOLVE BEFORE ORDERING

A Xenium custom add-on is capped at 100 genes on top of a pre-designed base panel. Our list is 168.

Option A (preferred): Xenium Prime 5K mouse panel as the base. It should already contain nearly all 164 endogenous genes, leaving only the 4 transgenes as custom.

Option B: base mouse brain panel + 100-gene add-on. Feasible because the 77-gene minimum panel plus the transgenes fits inside the cap. This is exactly why I tiered the list.

Action: cross-check our 168 genes against the base panel gene lists and get a quote for both options. Two days of work, must happen before the October order.

Statistics caveat: n=3 per group means the unit of inference is the mouse, not the cell. I will analyse cells nested within mouse and report mouse-level effects. Treat Experiment 1 as descriptive; if QC passes I would extend to n=5 per group.

Experiment 1 — schedule

The September pilot deliberately uses the base panel only, so tissue QC is not blocked by panel design

When	Step	What must be true to proceed
Sep 2026	Xenium pilot with Alina's lab. Base mouse brain panel only, 1 Active + 1 Passive brain from existing tissue.	Nothing — this is the gate, and it needs no new panel.
Sep 2026	QC criteria fixed in advance: transcripts per cell, negative-probe rate, segmentation quality, registration of ORBm and BMAP to Allen, and recovery of the expected subclasses.	Agree the numeric thresholds with Alina BEFORE the run, so pass/fail is not a judgement call.
Sep-Oct 2026	Cross-check the 168 genes against base panel content; quote Prime 5K vs base + 100 add-on.	Pilot QC passed.
Oct 2026	Submit panel design, including the 4 transgene FASTA sequences (tdTomato, iCre, and EGFP/WPRE if wanted).	Budget option chosen; Ai14 and TRAP2 construct sequences in hand.
Oct-Nov 2026	Panel manufacture and delivery (allow 6-8 weeks).	Order placed.
Nov 2026	Run the behaviour cohort for Experiment 1 (n=3+3) so tissue is ready when the panel arrives.	Mice genotyped TRAP2;Ai14; 4-OHT prepared fresh.
Dec 2026 - Jan 2027	Xenium run on ORBm and BMAP; analysis.	Panel delivered; sections cut and QC'd.

The one thing that can slip this schedule is the panel cross-check. If we discover in October that our genes do not fit the cap, we lose the manufacturing slot.

Experiment 2 — the problem with my first sketch

Injecting CNO on Post day 7 would have tested nothing, because the receptor is not there yet

TRAP IS INTRINSICALLY RETROSPECTIVE

To be tagged, a neuron must be active. To be silenced, it must first manufacture the receptor. Those cannot happen at the same time.

So TRAP can never answer 'does activity during Post cause behaviour during Post'. It answers 'are the neurons that were active during Post required for behaviour later'.

This is a property of the method, not a flaw in the plan — but it decides what the experiment is allowed to claim.

AND THE ARITHMETIC DOES NOT WORK

AAV-DIO-hM4Di needs about 14 days after 4-OHT before hM4Di is functional, on top of ~3 weeks for the AAV itself before tagging.

My sketch: 4-OHT on Post day 2 (behaviour day 12), CNO on 'Post day 7' — five days later.

Five days is not enough. We would inhibit nothing, see no behavioural effect, and be unable to tell that apart from the hypothesis being wrong.

Requirement	Needs	My sketch gave it	Verdict
AAV established before tagging	~21 days	not specified	fixable
hM4Di functional after 4-OHT	~14 days	5 days	FAILS
Post phase long enough to test inside it	~17 days	3 days (day 11-13)	FAILS

A null result from an underpowered, under-expressed experiment is the worst outcome available to us: it costs a full cohort and answers nothing. The next slide is the fix.

Experiment 2 — the constraint points at the right experiment

Three independent timescales all land on the same window, about two weeks after the last morphine

Timescale	Value	Source
hM4Di becomes functional after 4-OHT	~14 days	TRAP2 + AAV-DIO-DREADD studies
Incubation of craving peaks	~withdrawal day 14	Fos ensemble studies, inverted-U across drugs
OFC inactivation reduces opioid seeking	at day 15, NOT at day 1	Oxycodone incubation, OFC inactivation

The technique is ready exactly when the behaviour is maximal, and exactly when the region is known to matter. The delay we were fighting is the delay we want.

WHAT CHANGES, AND WHAT DOES NOT

Does NOT change: behaviour days 1-18 stay exactly as run. Same FR, Pre, During, Post, Withdrawal, Re-exposure. The whole-brain TRAP and Xenium data still map on.

Changes: we add a home-cage abstinence period and a drug test at the end. We add days after day 18; we do not alter days 1-18.

That is the whole argument for this redesign — it is additive, not a new paradigm.

THE QUESTION, RESTATED HONESTLY

Cannot test: does Post activity cause Post seeking?

Can test, and this was the second half of my own hypothesis:

Are ORBm / BMAp neurons that were active during Post necessary for morphine seeking after protracted abstinence, and is that requirement specific to mice that earned the drug?

This is also the more clinically relevant question. Patients do not relapse during use; they relapse after abstinence.

IF YOU WANT THE WITHIN-POST TEST ANYWAY

There is a way to do it at 48 h instead of 14 days. Slide 13.

Experiment 2 — design

2 × 2 between subjects, drug crossed within subject; one region at a time

	Levels	Purpose
Group (between)	Active / yoked Passive	The Active-only prediction. Passive is the specificity control.
Virus (between)	AAV-DIO-hM4Di-mCherry / AAV-DIO-mCherry	The mCherry + drug arm is the essential control: it removes any effect of the ligand itself. More important than a saline arm.
Drug (WITHIN subject)	DCZ 0.1 mg/kg / vehicle, crossover	Each mouse is its own control, which roughly halves the mice needed.
Region	ORBm first, then BMAP	ORBm has the larger Active–Passive difference and is the easier bilateral target. BMAP second, informed by the Xenium result.

Starting coordinates to verify in cohort 1, then fix: ORBm ~ AP +2.6, ML ±0.35, DV −2.7; BMAP ~ AP −1.8, ML ±2.4, DV −5.1. Use 150-250 nl at low rate — BMAP sits next to MEA, BLA and the sAMY-like GABA populations our marker work flagged, so spread must be verified histologically.

n per cell	dz=0.8	dz=1.0	dz=1.2	dz=1.5
4 (my sketch)	21%	29%	38%	53%
8	50%	68%	83%	95%
10	62%	80%	92%	99%
12	71%	88%	97%	100%

Power, paired t-test, two-tailed α=0.05

- Reported chemogenetic effects on drug seeking are large, roughly a 40-50% reduction, so dz ~ 1.0-1.2 is a fair planning assumption.
- n=4 detects nothing smaller than dz~1.6. n=10 is the first row where a large effect is reliably detectable.

What I propose instead of choosing one n

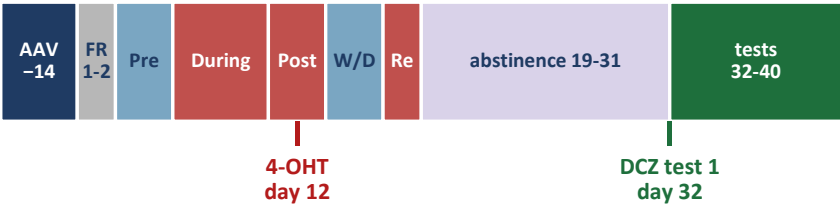
- Cohort 1 = expression pilot, n=4 per cell (16 mice, ORBm). No behavioural inference claimed. It buys the AAV coordinates, the percentage of tdTomato+ cells that become hM4Di+, confirmation that DCZ suppresses Fos in those cells, and a variance estimate.
- Cohort 2 = powered, n=10 per cell (40 mice, ORBm), with n set by cohort 1's variance rather than by my guess.
- Allow ~25% attrition for missed targeting and health, so order accordingly.

Experiment 2 — day-by-day schedule

Behaviour days 1-18 are unchanged; everything new is appended after day 18

Day	Phase / step	Reward	Note
-14	Bilateral AAV surgery (hM4Di or mCherry), ORBm	—	26 days before tagging, comfortably past the ~21-day AAV requirement
-13 to 0	Recovery, handling, injection habituation	—	Handling matters: it lowers TRAP background labelling
1-2	Fixed ratio	—	As currently run
3-5	Pre	Water	As currently run
6-10	During	Morphine	Passive lick lockout applies, as currently run
11-13	Post	Morphine	4-OHT 50 mg/kg i.p. right after the DAY 12 session
14-16	Withdrawal	Water	As currently run
17-18	Re-exposure	Morphine	As currently run. Day 18 = last morphine
19-31	Forced abstinence, home cage	—	hM4Di matures (19 days post-4-OHT by day 31) and craving incubates
32	TEST 1 — cue-induced seeking, no morphine	—	DCZ or vehicle 15 min before. Withdrawal day 14. Primary endpoint
34	TEST 2 — same test, treatment crossed over	—	48 h washout is ample for DCZ
36	SPECIFICITY — water or sucrose PR under DCZ	Water	Shows the effect is not general motivation
38	MOTOR — locomotion / open field under DCZ	—	Rules out a movement confound
40	Final session, sacrifice 90 min later	—	Histology: placement, tdTomato ∩ hM4Di overlap, Fos suppression

Same picture as one timeline



THE 20-DAY GAP IS THE POINT

Day 12 (4-OHT) to day 32 (first test) = 20 days.

hM4Di needs ~14 days after tagging → satisfied with 6 days of margin.

Your own requirement of at least 10 days after TRAP → satisfied.

Day 32 is withdrawal day 14 from the last morphine, which is where incubated opioid seeking peaks and where OFC inactivation is known to work.

Days 1-18 are untouched, so the whole-brain TRAP and Xenium results still describe this cohort.

■ morphine ■ water ■ abstinence ■ test

Experiment 2 — the controls a reviewer will ask for

Each one closes a specific alternative explanation

Control	What it rules out	Cost
AAV-DIO-mCherry + DCZ	That the ligand itself changed behaviour. This is the control that matters most and it is why I am not relying on a saline arm.	Built into the 2x2
Vehicle in hM4Di mice (crossover)	Baseline drift and order effects.	Free — within subject
No-4-OHT (oil vehicle) + AAV	Cre-independent recombination leak, i.e. hM4Di in cells that were never active.	3-4 mice, histology only
Home-cage 4-OHT, no session	That we tagged the paradigm rather than the Post state. Gives the background labelling rate to subtract.	3-4 mice, histology only
Water or sucrose PR under DCZ	A general drop in motivation or in licking ability.	One session, same mice
Locomotion under DCZ	A motor confound.	One session, same mice

Fos in hM4Di+ cells after DCZ	That we inhibited nothing. This is target engagement and without it a null result is uninterpretable.	Terminal histology
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USE DCZ, NOT CNO

CNO back-converts to clozapine in vivo, and clozapine crosses the blood-brain barrier and alters motivation on its own.

In a drug-seeking assay that confound sits directly on top of the dependent variable, so it is not a risk we should take.

DCZ: higher affinity, faster brain entry, no detectable activity across 318 off-target GPCRs. Effective at 0.1 mg/kg i.p. or lower.

OPEN QUESTION I NEED HELP WITH

The TRAP2 protocol single-houses mice for 48 h before tagging, to keep background labelling low.

Our yoked design pairs each Active with a Passive partner. If yoking requires them to be co-housed on day 12, we cannot single-house them.

Fallback: keep normal housing, treat both groups identically, and measure the background with the home-cage 4-OHT control rather than trying to eliminate it.

If you want inhibition inside the Post window

There is a clean way to do it, but it needs new breeding — so I propose it as phase 2

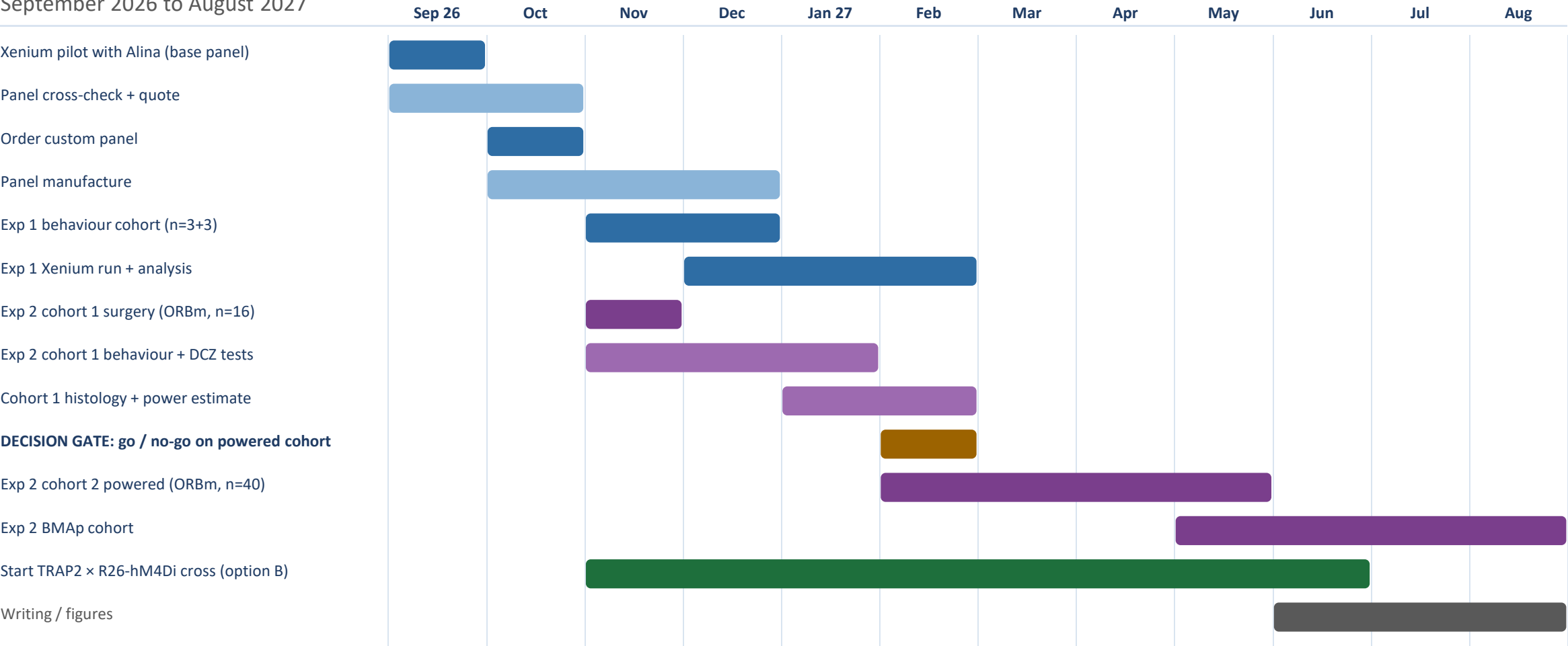
	A — Protracted abstinence (RECOMMENDED, start Nov)	B — Transgenic hM4Di + cannula (phase 2)	C — Extended Post (not recommended)
Effector	AAV-DIO-hM4Di into ORBm / BMAP	TRAP2 × R26-LSL-hM4Di (JAX 026219). Effector already in the genome, so no AAV lag	AAV-DIO-hM4Di
Delay from 4-OHT to test	~20 days	48 h	~15 days, but inside an extended Post
Region specificity	From the injection site	From local DCZ infusion through cannulae — the transgene is brain-wide	From the injection site
What it tests	Is the Post ensemble needed for relapse after abstinence?	Is the Post ensemble needed for seeking within the Post phase?	Same as B, but in a paradigm we have not characterised
Main cost	None beyond the appended days	New cross; Rosa26 conflict means this line cannot also carry Ai14, so the tag becomes mCitrine. Cannula surgery. 4-6 months of breeding	3 extra weeks of morphine per mouse, so drug history no longer matches the 18-day model behind our TRAP data
Ready to start	November 2026	Mid 2027 if we start breeding now	November 2026

My recommendation: run A now, and start the B cross in parallel so the within-Post question is answerable next year. A and B together are a much stronger story than either alone, because they separate 'needed while taking' from 'needed for relapse'.

48-h transgenic hM4Di precedent with intracerebral CNO: LEC engram study, bioRxiv 2025. R26-LSL-hM4Di: JAX 026219, Rosa26 locus — same locus as Ai14 (JAX 007914).

Master timeline

September 2026 to August 2027



The decision gate in February is deliberate: no powered cohort is ordered until cohort 1 has shown that hM4Di reaches the tagged cells and that DCZ suppresses their activity.

What I need from you, and what could still go wrong

DECISIONS I NEED

1. Budget route for the panel: Xenium Prime 5K base, or base panel plus a 100-gene add-on. This changes what I can order in October.
2. Which region first for chemogenetics. I recommend ORBm — larger effect in the screen, easier bilateral target, and cortex is more forgiving of spread.
3. Group sizes: do you accept cohort 1 as an explicitly underpowered expression pilot, with the powered cohort gated on its result?
4. Housing on the tagging day — whether the yoked design can tolerate 48 h of single housing before day 12, or whether we measure background instead.
5. Sex as a variable. The current cohort needs checking; if it is male-only I would like to add females to the powered cohort rather than to the pilot.
6. Whether to start the TRAP2 × R26-hM4Di cross now, so the within-Post question is answerable in 2027.

RISKS, AND WHAT I WOULD DO

Custom transgene probes are not validated by 10x. If tdTomato detection is weak, iCre gives a second independent readout of the same cells, and immunostaining on adjacent sections is the fallback.

BMAp is small and next to MEA, BLA and the sAMY-like GABA populations. Mitigation: small injection volume, and every mouse verified histologically against the subclass markers from the panel work.

Our Post ensemble may not be one cell type. If Xenium shows it is heterogeneous, the chemogenetic result becomes harder to interpret — which is a reason to let Experiment 1 report before the powered cohort is locked.

Morphine dose and delivery volume are not written down anywhere I can find in the code or manifests. I need them for the methods section and for the licence.

Oral lick-based self-administration is less standard than IV, so reviewers will ask for intake per session in mg/kg. Worth agreeing how we report that now.

References for every parameter used in this deck

Claim in this deck	Source
TRAP2 labels within a ~6 h window centred on 4-OHT; 4-OHT 50 mg/kg i.p. at 10 mg/mL in 1:4 castor:sunflower oil; single housing 48 h before tagging	DeNardo LA et al. Temporal evolution of cortical ensembles promoting remote memory retrieval. Nat Neurosci 2019;22:460-469
TRAP2 = Fos2A-iCreER, JAX 030323; Ai14 = JAX 007914	DeNardo et al. 2019; Madisen L et al. Nat Neurosci 2010;13:133-140
AAV-delivered Cre-dependent DREADDs need ~2 weeks after 4-OHT, on top of ~3 weeks for AAV expression before tagging	López-Ferreras L et al. TRAPing ghrelin-activated circuits. Int J Mol Sci 2022;23:559; Cre-dependent AAV DREADD studies use 3-4 week expression windows
Transgenic Cre-dependent hM4Di can be used 48 h after tagging, with local intracerebral ligand infusion for region specificity	LEC engram cell study, bioRxiv 2025 (TRAP2 × hM4Di-DREADD, 48 h, intra-LEC CNO)
R26-LSL-hM4Di/mCitrine = JAX 026219, targeted to the Rosa26 locus (hence the conflict with Ai14)	Zhu H et al., Cre-dependent DREADD mice; JAX strain 026219; MGI:5614050
CNO is reverse-metabolised to clozapine and produces clozapine-like effects	Gomez JL et al. Science 2017;357:503-507; Manvich DF et al. Sci Rep 2018;8:3840
DCZ is more potent and selective than CNO; effective at 0.001-0.1 mg/kg with no activity across 318 off-target GPCRs	Nagai Y et al. Nat Neurosci 2020;23:1157-1167; Nentwig TB et al. Sci Rep 2022;12:6520
OFC inactivation reduces oxycodone seeking on withdrawal day 15 but not day 1	Fredriksson I / Shaham lab. Role of orbitofrontal cortex in incubation of oxycodone craving. Addict Biol 2020;25:e12927
Fos ensembles are causally required for opioid and nicotine seeking; incubation peaks around withdrawal day 14	Funk D et al. J Neurosci 2016 (CeA, nicotine); Fredriksson I et al. Sci Adv 2023 (vSub, oxycodone); Warren BL et al. Addict Biol 2022 (IL, oxycodone)
Xenium supports exogenous targets (reporters, transgenes) via advanced custom design from a FASTA of ≥80 bp, but 10x does not validate them; add-on panels are capped at 100 genes	10x Genomics CG000683 Xenium Custom Panel Design; CG000643 Designing Custom Xenium Panels